

MBA27 Advanced Sustainability

Disclaimer: Please note that this is a draft version of the course outline which is intended to serve as a reference during your advanced course selection. It has not been formally approved yet. The final version will be shared in the respective Canvas site once it's ready.

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Canvas course link	<i>To be added later</i>

FACULTY BIO



Lawrence Pratt is Professor of Sustainability and Entrepreneurship at INCAE Business School in Alajuela, Costa Rica www.incae.edu. He teaches sustainability strategy in INCAE's Masters degree and executive programs, and leads various programs related to entrepreneurship, focused on sustainability-oriented and women-led businesses. Mr. Pratt serves as a consultant and advisor in sustainable business development to various multilateral organizations, manufacturing, natural resources and financial services companies in the United States, Latin America and Europe. He is a graduate of the College of William and Mary in Williamsburg, Virginia, and holds a Masters of Public and Private Management degree from Yale University in New Haven, Connecticut. He is a past recipient of the Aspen Institute's "Faculty Pioneer Award" for "External Impact in Advancing Sustainability."

ABSTRACT

"Applied Sustainable Development in Business" is an advanced course exploring how the principles of sustainable development apply to strategic and operational aspects of businesses in different sectors of the economy. The course will explore current "best practices" in sustainability, the strategic and financial drivers behind these approaches and practices and consider their applicability more broadly across different types of businesses in different contexts.

The goal of the course is to introduce future managers and entrepreneurs to the practical application of sustainable development principles, strategies and practices that align companies' goals, and creation of value for the companies, their shareholders, other stakeholders and the broader society in which they operate. The "capstone" for this course will be the presentation of learning and recommendations to a Netherlands-based asset manager seeking to invest in businesses with superior sustainability practices and financial performance.

EDUCATIONAL GOALS

This course seeks to impart knowledge and skills that allow managers to distinguish between companies with different levels of commitment and adherence to sustainable principles in their business operations, and design approaches to align companies with more sustainable practices that drive business and broader societal goals. The specific educational goals are presented below.

Learning areas	Educational Goals
I. Content- related	Recognize and consider “best practices” in sustainability across several business types.
	Be able to define and discuss approaches to measuring and communicating sustainability to stakeholders for purposes of demonstrating sustainability performance.
	Understand the practical considerations for businesses and their financial stakeholders when incorporating sustainability issues
II. Skills-related	Propose and justify, as a member of team, appropriate actions that could or should be taken by companies or investors that would advance sustainability in a profitable manner.
	Define and recommend a concrete strategy to a financial institution seeking to grow its sustainability-oriented investment portfolio
III. Attitude-related	Ability to reflect on the role of managers and entrepreneurs on multiple stakeholders when selecting different strategic approaches toward sustainability.
	Reflect on the interconnected nature of economic, environmental and social needs in our society and the practical challenges of translating these into concrete business action.

FIT WITHIN THE RSM ERASMUS MBA AND RELATION TO THE RSM MISSION: A FORCE FOR POSITIVE CHANGE*

This course contributes to the overall program/curriculum objectives by providing specific skills and experience that advance both understanding of sustainability in business and a practical capacity to analyse and recommend value creating approaches derived from sustainability in a larger context of the global society. The Advanced Sustainability course directly addresses the role of business and management in advancing strategies that permit business to create value while addressing critical changes facing our society. The course provides students with a hands-on experience using previously acquired and new skills, frameworks, and tools to consider these challenges in the context of management decisions that they will be called on to make in the very near future. The course builds on the Business of Sustainability introductory course and provides the basis for further courses in the sustainability area. The content incorporates the learning and content of other MBA courses, such as: strategy, finance and marketing, and requires students to consider their learning from these courses in developing concrete strategic recommendations.

By providing the analytical and content-related foundations for guiding business decisions related to sustainability currently and in the future, the course directly supports future graduates with the knowledge, frameworks and tools to actually become a “Force for Positive Change.”

* It's RSM's mission to be a force for positive change in the world. For this, RSM is committed to the United Nation's [17 Sustainable Development Goals](#) as the framework for defining 'positive change'. For the purpose of the RSM Erasmus MBA, we strive to provide our students with the opportunity to master competencies that enable them to successfully lead teams, business units and organizations while they navigate and accelerate transitions towards more just, sustainable and resilient societies. We report the amount of lecture time across all of our MBA courses that is devoted directly to such mission-relevant learning. We have further broken this down into environment, social, and governance related topics.

TEACHING METHODS AND WORKLOAD

Participants will be assigned reading and task-driven assignments for each class session, with written assignments for submission due approximately every third session. Some assignments will be individual, others in group, but the objective of each assignment is to understand material, form coherent fact-supported arguments, and present and discuss these with the group under the Instructors' guidance. Each assignment builds on previous assignments and provides the basis for subsequent learning.

The final three sessions of the course will be focused on applying the learning from the previous sessions to proposing a "real life" solution to managers of a Netherlands-based asset management company. During these sessions, participants will present proposals, receive feedback from the instructor and "client" to fine-tune and strengthen the proposals, work iterative versions of the proposals, and present a final version. Supporting material for the assignments will include articles from academic, business and popular press; standards and certification guidance; corporate sustainability reports and annual reports. Inputs from these materials will be the basis for developing fact-supported positions discussed in class and reflected in submitted assignments and the final "capstone" presentation.

Participants are expected to 1) prepare each assignment individually and prepare to present and defend their work to (and with) their peers and Instructor; 2) engage and participate actively in the sessions contributing to group learning, 3) contribute as active and effective members of their teams for group assignments, 4) contribute meaningfully in the final assignment, including presenting and engaging with the "client" organization. Each participant will, as part of assigned teams, prepare and present specific assignments as a group, as designated by the Instructor. The capstone assignment will be carried out in assigned teams. The goals of this group work are to deepen understanding of the assignments and their learning objectives, and also to practice effectively operating in cross-cultural teams and enhance interpersonal communication skills between classmates/team members.

The following table summarizes the expected level of effort required for the different components of this course and the calculations for determining ECTS units.

Description	Calculation	Total
In-Class sessions:	10 sessions x 2.5 hours	25 hours
Individual and group for class preparation:	10 hours x 4	40 hours
Team Assignment(s)	2 assignments x 8 hours	16 hours
Individual Assignment(s)	1 assignment x 6 hours	6 hours
Final presentation	1 session x 2 hours Preparation for session	18 hours
Final paper	7 hours	7 hours
Total Course Hours		112 hours
EC (4)	4 EC x 28 hours	112 Total hours

GRADING AND ASSESSMENT

The tables below explain the components of the final grade, and the criteria for evaluating each component. Minimum requirements to earn a passing grade for the course are:

- Preparation for, and active participation in, class discussions.
- Successful completion of all individual and group assignments.
- Engagement with assigned team on discussions and in preparation of group assignments.

Course: Advanced Sustainability	Assessment formats				
Educational goals per course	Contribution to Peers' Learning	Team Assignment	Team Final Presentation	Final Reflective Paper	Total
Recognize and consider “best practices” in sustainability across several business types.		X		X	
Be able to define and discuss approaches to measuring and communicating sustainability to stakeholders for purposes of demonstrating sustainability performance.		X	X	X	
Understand the practical considerations for businesses and their financial stakeholders when incorporating sustainability issues.			X	X	
Propose and justify, as a member of team, appropriate actions that could or should be taken by companies or investors that would advance sustainability in a profitable manner.	X		X	X	
Define and recommend a concrete strategy to a financial institution seeking to grow its sustainability-oriented investment portfolio		X	X		
Reflect on the interconnected nature of economic, environmental and social needs in our society and the practical challenges of translating these into concrete business action.	X	X	X		
Ability to reflect on the role of managers and entrepreneurs on multiple stakeholders when selecting different strategic approaches toward sustainability.	X			X	
Weighting factor	20%	10%	40%	30%	100%
Minimum grade required	N/A	5.5	5.5	5.5	5.5
When failed, resit option within academic year	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	
Form of examination (e.g. MC, Open-book, etc.)	Continuous in-class	In-class interim presentation	Final Presentation	Final paper	
Group / Individual assessment (Group/Individual)	I	G	G	I	

In order to pass the course, each assessment or deliverable (component grade) with a resit option, needs to be at least 5.5. Components with no resit option bear no minimum grade required, but to pass the overall course, the final grade needs to be at least 5.5.

Grades are rounded according to the rounding provisions included in the Teaching and Examination Regulations (TER) of the programme, and are expressed with 1 decimal point. Not meeting the minimum grade required for either a component grade or the overall course grade determines a fail for the course. Participants can resit a failed component only once. There is no capping of the grade for a resit examination. The only exception is when the nature of the failed assignment allows for an improvement effort of the same assignment (capped at 5.5 for that component). For this particular course, the faculty has decided that all assignments allow for an improvement effort.

Grade penalties for unauthorized late submissions will be automatically imposed. Penalties for unauthorised late submissions range from 10% to 20% deduction from the examination component depending on the hours/days late. Unauthorised late submissions 4 days or longer after the deadline without prior notification and a reasonable explanation for the late submission, will not be accepted.

Attendance is mandatory and a requirement to pass the course. Missing classes and arriving late may result in grading penalties. Missing two classes will result in an automatic fail for the course.

Fraud, Plagiarism / Self-plagiarism (Refer to separate RSM Code of Conduct, Rules and Guidelines, and Teaching and Examination Regulations)

The Examination Board defines fraud as *“the action or negligence of a student because of which it is impossible, entirely, or partially, to form a correct judgment about the knowledge, insight, and skills of them or another student”* (R&Gs and TERs). Examples of fraud are cheating, cribbing, plagiarism, freeriding in a team assignment, availability of unauthorized (study) material during a test such as mobile phones, contract cheating/outsourcing/ghost-writing, unauthorized use of generative AI, identity fraud, theft.

Confirmed cases of fraud/plagiarism will lead to (appropriate and proportional) sanctions as defined by the Examination Board in the Rules and Guidelines (R&G). Repetitive cases of fraud/plagiarism lead to expulsion from the programme.

Plagiarism is presenting another person’s work as one’s own. Plagiarism includes any paraphrasing or summarising of the work of another person or group without acknowledgment, including submission of another student’s work as one’s own. Plagiarism frequently involves a failure to acknowledge the quotation of paragraphs, sentences, or even a few phrases written or spoken by someone else. Using ideas from your own prior work (assignment) without referencing the work in your assignment is considered self-plagiarism.

Participants are required to adhere to the 6 principles outlined in the RSM AI guidelines with regard to the use of Artificial Intelligence Platforms such as ChatGPT and related software/tools. The unauthorised use constitutes violation of plagiarism/ fraud policy. For this particular course, the faculty promotes an **“embraced”** use of AI.

For more information about academic integrity and AI please refer to the Programme’s Teaching and Examination Regulations and RSM AI guidelines documents on the [Student Hub](#) (Link).

Assessment / Deliverable:	Individual or group:	(Due) date and hand in location:	% of final grade:
Team Final Presentation (final recommendations)	Group	30 September 2026	40%
Team assignment (in-class interim presentation)	Group	23 September 2026	10%
Contribution to others’ learning (participation)	Individual	Continuous	20%
Final Individual Paper	Individual	14 October 2026	30%

Element	Criteria
Final Team Presentation/Report	• Demonstrated understanding of issues and integration of client's needs. • Quality of analysis (qualitative and quantitative) • Clarity and conciseness of presentation and focus on key issues • Quality of responses to questions • "Professionalism" (presence, clarity, time limits)
Team assignments (in-class interim presentation)	• Quality of analysis (qualitative and quantitative) • Clarity of presentation and focus on assigned points and key issues • Integration of learning points
Contribution to others' learning (participation)	• Quantity and quality of participation and the extent to which comments and questions advance group learning • Evidence of preparation for class supporting contributions • Peer evaluation survey
Final Reflective Paper	• Numerical score

For all Canvas submissions, please make sure to the student name, EUR student number, and programme name within the document itself (on the cover page), and your initials, EUR student number, and programme name in the title of the file submission.

REQUIRED TEXTBOOK(S) AND READINGS

There is no required textbook. Each session has assigned readings (case studies, articles from business, policy, popular and academic press) and/or videos. Much of the material in the course (particularly videos, background material and reference readings) is provided via links to the Web, as also noted in the Detailed Course Schedule. RSM's "Canvas" site for the course will contain the course syllabus, and other information.

SUGGESTED EXTRA READINGS, JOURNALS AND WEBSITES

"The Sustainable MBA: A Business Guide to Sustainability" (2nd Edition), by Giselle Weybrecht (Wiley), New York University Stern School Center for Sustainable Business

Landing page: (<https://www.stern.nyu.edu/experience-stern/about/departments-centers-initiatives/centers-of-research/center-sustainable-business>)

Return on Sustainable Investing (ROSI) database: <https://www.stern.nyu.edu/experience-stern/about/departments-centers-initiatives/centers-of-research/center-sustainable-business/research/return-sustainability-investment-rosi>

Unruh, Gregory, Strategy on the Sustainability Frontier, Global Leadership Academy Press (2020)

Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, "Climate Change 2022: Impacts, Adaptation and Vulnerability, Summary for Policymakers (<https://www.ipcc.ch/report/ar6/wg2/>)

Network for Business Sustainability <http://nbs.net>. "Academic and industry thought leaders sharing the best sustainability knowledge. We produce authoritative resources that help shape management practice".

World Business Council for Sustainable Development www.wbcsd.org "The WBCSD is a CEO-led organization of forward-thinking companies that galvanizes the global business community to create a sustainable future for business."

The Global Goals for Sustainable Development <https://www.globalgoals.org>

United Nations Global Compact <https://www.unglobalcompact.org/>

DETAILED COURSE SCHEDULE

Session 1	
Understanding Value Creation from Sustainability	This session reviews the objectives and methodology of the course and establishes the expectations and milestones. Explore the relationship between value creation and sustainability impact.
Assignment:	Watch assigned video and read the two assigned papers. Prepare answers to the following questions and be ready to discuss and defend your answers in class. ○ What are the arguments supporting greater value creation for investments in organizations with stronger environmental, social and governance (ESG) performance)? ○ How do we know/analyse/confirm if value is being created by a given strategy or company through its sustainability programs? ○ How can we assess value creation by incorporating (or not) stakeholder expectations?
Readings and preparation:	1) WBCSD Better Business Better World (Executive Summary) (see intro and pp 6 to 10 specifically). (on Canvas) 2) Estrada (IESE) Video 3) Global Sustainable Investment Alliance, "Global Sustainable Investment Review 2020". 4) Towle, M, Environmental, Social and Governance Investing: Myths versus Reality (from Investments and Wealth Monitor) Optional reading: McKinsey Does ESG really matter—and why? (McKinsey Quarterly August 2022)
Comments:	You may now have a different view of these two articles from the Intro course after digging deeper. Morgan Stanley: "Sustainable Reality: Analyzing Risk and Returns of Sustainable Funds" Short layperson article from Forbes describing ESG investing.

Session 2	
Presentation of Client and Assignment	This session introduces the course project. We will host senior personnel of the investment manager who will provide an overview of their business model and approach, and their goals for the project.

Assignment to prepare for class:	Review all materials provided and prepare questions (discuss and finetune in your teams) for the Representative. This will be the only opportunity for “real time” Q&A.
Readings and preparation:	Background Information on the investment fund and manager: To be provided.
Comments:	As this is our principle opportunity to meet with the investment manager, we need to be ready. It will be nearly impossible to discuss the assignment unless you have all really understood the content I have assigned.

Session 3	
“What does it mean to be a sustainable business and who is investing in what?”	This session has a dual purpose: 1) Understand investment managers’ goals, objectives and investment parameters. 2) Consider different understanding and interpretations of what “sustainable business” means and how to approach as analysts and investors.
Assignment:	Each team is to present a summary discussion of the key topics for the investment manager. To be determined. Discussion questions for class: ○ What are the key global and crosscutting sustainability issues (thematic) that emerge in the investor universe? How much consistency is there? ○ Where is there divergence or convergence among the potential investors in terms of their financial and other expectations for placed investments? ○ Who decides who is “good” or “bad” at sustainability (companies, investors)? How? Based on what?
Readings and preparation:	1) Own research to be determined 2) SPGlobal (previously Robeco/SAM, previously SAM) has rated publicly traded companies for sustainability for over 20 years. Review “S&P Global Sustainability Yearbook 2023” . Specifically: a) understand their Methodology and Reading Instructions (pages 12 to 16), b) be sure you understand the “Highlighted criteria & dimension weights” and then review and understand two industry summaries (per team) found in that report (page 21 onward).
Comments:	

Session 4.	
Understanding and Benchmarking Industry Leaders	This session seeks to understand and characterize how leading companies in specific sectors address sustainability concerns.

Assignment:	Identify three recognized industry leaders in your assigned business sectors from the 2025 SPGlobal Sustainability Report (make sure your team sees at least 3 different leaders in total to have a base for comparison and analysis). Retrieve and review their corporate sustainability report (which will almost certainly be GRI-compliant). Identify: - the key sustainability issues each company addresses (use the companies materiality matrix) - how the company manages and reports their impact (particularly commitments/goals and KPIs). Reference GRI points to organize your logic (note if there is a specific GRI sectoral guidance document for your sector, and use if appropriate). - key stakeholders explicitly or implicitly targeted/responded to by the report. - commonality of sustainability priorities (goals and items measured) across the industry leaders (yours and your teammates'), noting any key differences. Then assess: - which elements of the company's sustainability approach are "defensive" (risk-avoidance driven) and "offensive" (opportunity-driven)? - the relevance of what the company manages to its industry and markets it serves (e.g. why do they manage THOSE elements and how does it relate to their competitive position in their industry?). - which of the companies you saw (out of the four) appears to have the strongest approach? Why? How did you make your assessment? To be submitted: - Team report writing-up your findings for your two companies. Report should be 4 pages – maximum 2 pages of text on "identify" points, minimum of 2 pages of text on "assess points" plus supporting tables and annex if you wish).
Readings and preparation:	Review the SPGlobal (formerly Robeco/SAM) top list and Corporate Knights top list and choose 2 leading companies from your assigned sector, get their annual sustainability report. - SPGlobal (formerly Robeco/SAM) Sustainability Yearbook for their Sustainability Leaders list (p. 45 onward) - o Their methodology is found here and in the first sections of the Yearbook - Corporate Knights top 100. - o See methodology at https://www.corporateknights.com/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/2019-Global-100_Methodology-Final.pdf?v=20181205. - o And see their list at https://www.corporateknights.com/reports/2021-global-100/2021-global-100-ranking-16115328/
Comments:	N/A

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Session 5	
Aligning Investment Assessment and Criteria	Examine how investment criteria are considered in placements and how this relates to customer expectations.
Assignment:	Evaluate the value proposition of the investment manager and how it relates to the most significant sustainability and value driving issues in the sector you examined. ○ Map the specific elements of the investment managers' strategy and "promise" to its investors as they relate to the sector you examined in the previous assignment. ○ Compare against SPGlobal, and a relevant "Comparable" investor ○ The B Lab (B Corporation) people have an online assessment tool (with an option for small businesses) that is currently considered the most comprehensive look at sustainability issues when designing and evaluating impact https://bimpactassessment.net/. Create a fictional small company in your assigned sector, and complete the survey, noting the key issues to see which ones are considered, and how. ○ Do the investment manager's priorities align? Which KPIs appear to be the most relevant to that alignment (to the IM, potential clients and sector) ○ What are the value creation arguments that are appearing most attractive? ○ Which are the elements that best align to the potential investors being considered? Why those elements and those investors?
Readings and preparation:	B-Corporation Assessment Tool
Comments:	Interesting small business frameworks to expand understanding: FMO's toolkit for small business finance

Session 6	
"Considering sustainability in debt versus equity and smaller business."	Having examined leading company "best practice" in various sectors and how this aligns with potential investor interest, this session addresses how those best practices might translate into debt and equity placements, particularly with smaller companies.
Assignment:	TO BE DETERMINED
Reading and preparation:	tba
Comments:	tba

Session 7	
Impact Frameworks	This session begins preparation for the Client Presentation (in Session 9) by incorporating learning to date into the Client's frameworks for impact and investor/investment logic.
Assignment:	Prepare and present in class a proposed "impact logic framework" for the investment manager based on your analysis. Consider: The goal(s) of the investor, the alignment of those goals with the investment managers', the compatibility and alignment of their value propositions, balance of environmental and social variables, measurement considerations (KPIs linked to impact). Demonstrate/"Prove:" Using your sectoral analysis as a concrete example, demonstrate specifically how you define and defend alignment of goals and value proposition.
Readings and preparation:	1. Review and understand investment managers impact framework and logic/structure 2. Select a fund from a different asset manager (with similar goals of financial returns and impact) and asses how it frames desired impact – compare and contrast with the investment manager's proposition. 3. Assess your assigned sector's sustainable value-creating drivers and demonstrate how the investment manager's proposition would create value for the potential investors.
Comments:	tba

Session 8	
Building a value proposition	In this session, each group will present its proposed recommendations and supporting analysis to the entire class and instructor for input and feedback.
Assignment:	Make a presentation of no more than 10 minutes that addresses: To be determined. Consider feedback from colleagues and Instructor to advance toward Client Presentation. Note: Instructor will have office hours for any teams wanting to discuss or review their Client Presentation.
Readings and preparation:	tba

Session 9

Team Presentations to Client Fund Manager	During this extended session, all teams will present their proposed solution and recommendations to a small panel of judges selected by the Fund Manager and the instructor.
Assignment:	Each team will make a presentation of approximately 20 minutes, allowing 10 minutes for questions and answers. The specific Terms of Reference will be announced by the Instructor at least one week prior.

Session 10	
Course Review, Final Paper Instructions	During this final session: ○ the Instructor will lead a review of teams' presentations and provide general feedback. ○ the class will lead an interactive discussion on key learning points from the course. ○ the Instructor will provide instructions on the final assignment.

ASSIGNMENTS DESCRIPTION

Contribution to others' learning (participation) will be assessed on the basis on the quality and quantity of student's contributions to class discussion. There should ideally be contributions in every class that advance class discussion, understanding and provide some type of insight on the material. Contributions should be built on concepts or reframing of points, or discussion based on clear understanding of the material and preparation for class, and reflection on personal or professional experience. This is assessed by the Instructor with input from a student self-assessment. Assessment rubric will be provided.

Team assignment (in-class interim presentation). Each assigned team will: a) Identify three recognized industry leaders in your assigned business sectors from the 2025 S&P Global Sustainability Report (make sure your team sees at least 3 different leaders in total to have a base for comparison and analysis); b) Retrieve and review their corporate sustainability report (which will almost certainly be GRI-compliant). C) Prepare a Team report writing-up your findings for assigned questions (to be provided) for the three companies. Report should be 4 pages – maximum 2 pages of text on “identify” points, minimum of 2 pages of text on “assess points” plus supporting tables and annex if you wish). Assessment rubric will be provided.

Team Final Presentation. Each team will present its analysis and recommendations to the financial institution “client” responding to the “Writ” and “Terms of reference” agreed with the FI client. The assigned grade will include input from the financial institution and Instructor. Assessment rubric will be provided.

Final Individual Paper. This will be a timed, on-line, assignment designed to allow course participants to demonstrate understanding and ability to apply learning from the course, as well as reflect on key issues considered throughout the course.

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